Workflow Drift Correction Guide

NurseBridge Training Lab – Scenario 4

Purpose

This guide helps trainers identify workflow drift, understand why it develops, and implement effective retraining strategies that restore safe and consistent EHR use.

What is Workflow Drift?

Workflow drift occurs when staff gradually move away from the intended EHR workflow and develop local shortcuts or workarounds. These behaviors often feel efficient but can negatively impact data integrity, reporting, and patient safety.

Step 1: Identify the Drift

1. What steps are being skipped or changed?
2. Where are staff documenting instead of the intended location?
3. How widespread is the behavior?
4. When did this pattern begin?

Step 2: Understand Why It Happened

1. Perceived inefficiency in the original workflow
2. Peer-to-peer teaching of shortcuts
3. Lack of reinforcement after training
4. High workload or time pressure
5. Unclear understanding of workflow purpose

Risks of Workflow Drift

1. Inconsistent documentation
2. Inaccurate reporting and analytics
3. Missed clinical information
4. Compliance and audit risks
5. Reduced patient safety

Step 3: Build a Retraining Plan

1. Clearly demonstrate the correct workflow
2. Explain why the workflow matters (not just how)
3. Compare correct workflow vs workaround
4. Use real examples from the unit
5. Provide short, focused retraining sessions

Step 4: Communicate Effectively

Avoid blame. Frame the correction as a workflow improvement. Acknowledge staff workload and explain how the correct workflow supports safety and efficiency.

Step 5: Reinforce and Monitor

1. Observe workflow after retraining
2. Use super users or champions
3. Reinforce during huddles
4. Provide quick reference tip sheets
5. Follow up within 1–2 weeks

Common Trainer Mistakes

1. Correcting behavior without understanding root cause
2. Blaming staff instead of addressing workflow challenges
3. Providing one-time training without follow-up
4. Ignoring unit culture and peer influence

Final Reminder

Workflow drift is normal in complex environments. Effective trainers correct it through understanding, clear communication, and consistent reinforcement—not blame.